theseus

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/53750707.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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by hopelessgemini

Summary

catra slips herself into the water with no small amount of effort. her entire body locks up once her torso hits the surface. something deep and broken inside of her insists that she's going to drown, or that she's back in prime's pool again, sinking deeper and deeper into the hazy green.

still, the water is hot. what passed for water on prime's ship wasn't hot; it was thick and lukewarm and oily, and smelled like burning tar. still, she can work her fingers through the fur matted with blood on her side and try to get the worst out. still, the springs are far enough away from her camp that she doesn't feel bad about relaxing here, even if there's a pretty good likelihood that she's going to die of blood loss in the water.

fuck, she wishes the horde's training had been a little more concerned with preventing children from dying.

or, catra tries to conceal some pretty life-threatening injuries and fails miserably. written for etherealshay for the seasons skirmish event!

Notes

I CANNOT STRESS THIS ENOUGH!!! this fic is about catra actively working to conceal an injury from the bfs and struggling with suicidal ideation!!! please take care of yourself and head on out if you're not in the space to read this rn for any reason!!

this fic was written for the secret solstice event! i'm having a great time working on stuff for it but i also knew i needed to get this out quickly before i sort of flailed around and died so here it is lmao in all its first draft glory

title comes from the song theseus by the oh hellos, which is a band i am completely fine and normal and cool about

See the end of the work for more notes

Her shirt is sticky with blood. Catra wrestles it over her head first, then cuts the bandage loose with her claws. The material is far too thick for her to cut it off in one go, but her head is clear enough for her to recognise that trying to use her pocket knife instead would be the worst possible thing she could do, so she suffers through the feeling of the webbing catching on her nails and tries to do tallies in her head while she works through the fabric.

She isn't sure how much blood she's lost. She isn't sure how long they've been walking. She isn't sure how much the bandage helped, and she isn't sure if the shitty Horde first aid kit she's been carrying around since before the end of the war is even worth the effort it takes to conceal it in her backpack. She doesn't even know how long she's got left until she passes out and dies before Adora can find her.

Catra swings herself around and slides her legs into the water. Better to die here, with most of the blood washed away, than let Adora see just how much she's been dealing with. Better to get rid of the evidence so she won't look like such a monumental idiot in her eyes.

She should have spoken to someone about it — if not Adora, Miss Magical Healing herself, then Bow or Perfuma or hell, even Glimmer — but there's still the remains of that terrified child in her, the one who knows weakness like the back of her own hand. She knows if she'd tried she wouldn't have been able to get a word out.

Because that's the thing, isn't it? She won't ever be free of that ghost. She can't even trust her friends (her family, soon) enough to tell them when she's hurt. She's terrified of the quiet judgement in Adora's eyes, the look that says *I can't believe you were stupid enough to get injured* , the feeling of electricity crackling up her back and into her spine —

("And I think you're afraid of being pitied," Perfuma says sympathetically.

They're picking flowers in the garden. Well, Perfuma is. Catra is sitting with her legs crossed on a warm slab of stone, pretending not to die inside.

"Who qualified you to be a therapist?" she mutters instead of answering, picking at a blade of grass. Perfuma would kill her on the spot if she uprooted it, so she runs the rounded top of her claws up and down the ridge in the centre in time with her breathing instead. It's nowhere near a meditation technique, but it keeps her breath slow and even, and it's something to do with her hands that doesn't involve accidentally cutting through her shirt.

Perfuma hums, politely ignoring the sarcasm. "Well, we have a very complex healthcare system in Plumeria. I'm nothing like the real deal, but I did pick up some things. I'm very good at affirmations of self-worth."

Catra snorts. "Yeah, Scorpia mentioned something like that."

“Well, if you’re finished trying to change the subject —”

Catra groans. “Oh, please don’t.”

“ — I think you’re afraid of being pitied because of your upbringing. And I think you’re afraid of being a burden to Adora, because of how much she risked to bring you back into her life again. Which, if I may, she did because she loves and cares about you.”

Catra exhales sharply, and then realises that this has doomed her. Perfuma is very good at reading her physical responses. She should have known better than to let her guard down.

Oh, well. She’s practising being open and honest and shit like that. “Yeah, I guess. I dunno.”

Perfuma laughs delightedly. “What do you associate with pity, Catra?”

“Um.” Catra shifts uncomfortably. Suddenly the sun seems too hot, the breeze too stiff. She fights the urge to bolt. “Feeling useless. Or worthless, or whatever. Feeling like it’s just other people’s charity that’s keeping me around.”

“Mhm,” Perfuma says, “thank you for being honest with me. I really appreciate it.”

Oh, she's — oh.

Catra shifts again, pulling her knees up to her chest. She feels safer like this, tucked into herself like a small child. "Yeah, I guess.")

Catra slips herself into the water with no small amount of effort. Her entire body locks up once her torso hits the surface. It's a reaction she's never been able to quite shake, even after months of working in Salenias and getting used to the pools and the impractical waterfalls in Adora's room. Something deep and broken inside of her insists that she's going to drown, or that she's back in Prime's pool again, sinking deeper and deeper into the hazy green. Still that terrified child, still those shattered remains of a 21-year-old who wanted to hurt the world back.

Still, the water is hot. What passed for water on Prime's ship wasn't hot; it was thick and lukewarm and oily, and smelled like burning tar. Still, she can work her fingers through the fur matted with blood on her side and try to get the worst out. Still, the springs are far enough away from her camp that she doesn't feel bad about relaxing here, even if there's a pretty good likelihood that she's going to die of blood loss in the water.

Fuck, she wishes the Horde's training had been a little more concerned with preventing children from dying.

The springs are ringed with thick stone. Catra sinks down into the water until only her head is above the surface and breathes out, long and slow, and then begins the long and arduous task of cleaning her blood off the rocks. Her arms are burning with exertion. She's only hurt this much once before — twice, maybe, although she hadn't been alive for much longer after the second time. And she'd been missing about half of her body the first time, so really there wasn't much left to hurt.

She pulls her shirt into the water with her next, in the hope that the water will wash the blood on it away. She isn't quite sure what she's going to do about the bandage or the blood on her backpack back in her tent at the camp, but if she regains enough strength to get out of the water at some point she'll cross that bridge when she comes to it. If she doesn't — well, it's not her problem anymore, is it?

The pool lies in a natural bend in a slow-moving creek, and the current is just about fast enough to carry the blood in the water downstream. There's mud in her fur too, thick and matted against the soles of her feet and the palms of her hands from when she'd dragged herself to cover earlier, turning the knees of her trousers almost completely black.

She looks utterly miserable, is the thing. But they all do, after battles like these.

Catra pulls the shirt over to her until it's pressed flat against her chest under the water. Her arms and side are screaming with a deep, burning ache — the kind that says *there will be more of your blood washing away to sea soon* . She closes her eyes, lets the water ebb and flow around her face.

Maybe she falls asleep. Maybe she passes out. Her thoughts are all blurred together, sticking and grasping and melting when she tries to reach out and touch them. It could be hours when she opens her eyes next; it could be seconds.

Either way, she's in pretty deep shit.

"Hi, Adora," she says weakly.

Adora's hair is down and wet, clinging slickly to her neck and drenching the neck of her shirt. Still standard Horde wear; she hasn't quite recovered that far yet. She must have just come back from the shower, or what passes for it in the rudimentary camp they've set up in her absence. Her eyes are glowing a faint blue that Catra knows for a fact means fear, means that her magic has started leaking out of her from desperation.

"Never scare me like that again," she says, voice hoarse.

"Huh?"

Adora wraps her hands around her middle, fingers tightening into fists in the fabric. "Where'd you get that cut?"

"Oh," Catra says eloquently. "Um. What cut?"

She grits her teeth. “Why didn’t you tell me you were hurt?”

Shit shit shit. Catra shrugs, lifting her shoulders out of the water. She moves to sit upright against the lip of stone behind her and discovers that it hurts too much to be worth the effort. “I dunno. Didn’t think it was worth the energy.”

Adora’s weird tense expression dips sharply into something uncomfortably sympathetic. “ *Catra* .”

She hesitates for a moment, shifting on the balls of her feet, and then bends down into the water and scoops Catra out of it. It’s so abnormally easy for her, as easy as breathing, and yet when her hands hook under Catra’s shoulders and thighs and lift gently the pain is so blinding that she nearly blacks out.

She decides, then, that it’s almost definitely the worst pain she’s ever felt. At least right in this moment, when all she can do is gasp and claw at Adora’s shoulders and she’s so, so tired —

“Holy fuck,” Adora says. Catra blinks blearily up at her and discovers that she did not, somehow, die and go to hell.

“It’s not that bad,” she mumbles.

“You’re literally losing consciousness in my arms right now. Like, I picked you up out of the pool and you almost blacked out.”

“‘S not that bad. I’m fine.”

Adora hisses through her teeth, which she only really does when she’s mad at herself, so Catra assumes she’s in the clear for now. “Were you hoping you’d just pass out in the water and die so you wouldn’t have to deal with the consequences? ‘Cause that isn’t how this works, Catra. I can’t fucking *believe* I didn’t —”

“That’s almost exactly what I was hoping, actually.”

“Yeah, I fucking bet it was.” She laughs, kind of a little too wild for Catra’s taste, but her hands are cradling her head so gently that she can’t really bring herself to think about it much more. Her fingers are shaking where they press against her skull, probably getting even more blood in her hair than before. “What did you think was gonna happen when I found you? Because I was gonna find you, Catra. I’m always gonna find you. Did you think I’d just let you die?”

“I didn’t want to be a burden,” she says quietly. It slips out far too easily for her own liking, but her head is pounding so hard that she can’t think straight.

Adora’s jaw drops. Her mouth works for a second, flailing for something to say.

"Don't give me that look; it makes me feel gross," Catra complains. This is code for *I hate it when you look at me like you've only just re-discovered how fucked up I am, because even though you're right it makes me want to claw myself open and find where the problem is* — and nineteen and a half years of knowing each other means that Adora can see right through her like glass.

Her mouth snaps shut again. She sets Catra down on the stone, frowning apologetically. "Sorry. You — scared me, is all. I don't — I don't know how to react when I see you hurt like this. I didn't mean to make you feel —"

"Are you gonna heal me or what?" is all Catra says. Even half-conscious and covered in her own blood, she can see Adora itching to transform, fingers flexing back and forth in the air over the hole gouged in her abdomen.

She waves a hand, spraying water droplets all over Catra's (thoroughly damp) face. "Yeah, yeah. Hold still, dumbass."

"You're calling *me* a dumbass?" Catra snorts, but she holds still.

She passes out.

When she comes back into consciousness, the pain in her side is gone. As is the mind-numbing fog, which is more of a relief. Catra blinks up at the ceiling of the tent and raises her arm experimentally, breathing in deep.

No pain at all.

She turns her head to the side and says "Thank you," to Adora, who is kneeling on the floor beside her bed with her head propped on the mattress.

"How'd you know I was here?"

"You always are," she says.

Adora tilts her head to the side, hair flopping over her eyes. It's dry now. She must have been out for a while, unless the transformation had decided to fix it for her. "True," she says softly, and, frowning, "I'm sorry."

Catra flexes her extended arm, revelling in the lack of deep tugging pain between her ribs. "Uh huh. For what?"

Adora's frown deepens. "About six or seven different things, really."

"Uh huh," Catra echoes, and then remembers that she'd found her bleeding and most likely dying in a pool and sort of hoping that the water would wash away all the evidence of her ever having existed, and she adds, "Don't be."

She shifts a little. "I overreacted."

Catra snorts. "Adora. Please."

"This isn't even *supposed* to be about me. You — I mean — *you* —"

She sits up all at once, which turns out to be a mistake because it makes her immediately break out into a coughing fit. Adora springs to her feet and starts patting her awkwardly on the back.

"Sorry. Just — wow, Adora," she manages.

Adora's face crinkles up. "What's that supposed to mean?"

“I don’t matter. Not in that way, that’s not what I mean. You —”

“I snapped at you while you were basically dying in my arms when I should have been fixing the problem first and asking questions later,” she recites mechanically, like she’s fucking practiced. Of course she has; it’s Adora. “And then you practically admitted to my face that you thought dropping everything to help you if you were hurt wouldn’t be worth the trouble.”

“It isn’t,” Catra says, quite honestly.

“It *is* ,” Adora insists, and her breath catches when she says, “Catra, if anything happened to you, I would move mountains to make sure you were okay.”

(“I think,” Perfuma begins, with something particularly knowing in her voice that Catra doesn’t like, “that you don’t realise just how much Adora cares about you.”

She huffs. “Oh, believe me, I *realise* .”

“Mhm,” Perfuma says idly.

“I mean, you know the shit she’s done for me.”

“I do.”

Her hands curl into grass. She resists the urge to start pulling up fistfulls. “She came back for me. I owe her my life.”

It’s Perfuma’s turn to laugh. “You don’t owe her anything, silly.”

It’s been so long since someone last called her *silly* that it catches her off guard. Catra has never been anything remotely close to silly. “What?”

“You don’t owe her anything,” she repeats simply. “Love isn’t transactional, Catra.”

“Well, yes, I know that, but —”

“Oh, I’m sure,” Perfuma hums.)

“Listen, we’ll talk about it later.”

Adora’s eyebrows shoot up. “Later?”

“Later,” Catra says agreeably. “When you’re not covered in my blood.”

Adora blinks up at her, then down at her shirt. She makes a small *oh* sound.

“Yeah. ‘Cause this is important — believe me, I don’t think it’s not — but, like —” Catra gestures to herself, then to Adora’s shirt, “neither of us are in the right state of mind to talk about it.”

Her frown smooths over. She nods, once, and then her face splits into a smile (radiant as always; if she wasn’t feeling dizzy as fuck Catra would be opening her mouth to call her beautiful to her face). “Someone’s been talking to Perfuma.”

Catra snorts. This turns out to be a mistake; her head starts spinning and she has to squeeze her eyes shut to make it stop. “She wishes.”

“You have,” Adora sing-songs.

She leans over to kiss Catra lightly on the lips, cutting off whatever indignant response she might have made.

The second most exciting incident of the day occurs when Catra tries to get out of bed to fetch herself a meal from the campfire and promptly collapses onto her knees. She lets Adora lay her back down on the rug without much protest, scowling up at the roof of the tent while she blasts her with healing magic for the millionth time.

This is, of course, when Glimmer comes in. She glances between them — the newly healed scar on Catra's side, smoothed down flat against her skin by some She-Ra shit she's too tired to understand; Adora with her hands held still over Catra's body and her eyes glowing blue-white-gold — and lets out a little screaming gasp she'd probably find incredibly funny if her head wasn't swimming.

"It's not what it looks like," Adora says.

Catra gestures weakly to the scar on her side and the blood on Adora's shirt and supplies, "It's exactly what it looks like."

Adora's concentration wavers a little when Glimmer makes another scream-gasp sound and pain spikes up Catra's side and into the base of her neck. She winces, rocking tightly onto her side.

"I don't know exactly what it looks like except for *not fucking good* ."

Adora scrunches up her face, half exertion, half exhaustion. "D'you want to explain or shall I?"

Catra sighs through her nose. Her ribs feel at the very least badly bruised, which is a fascinating side effect of falling over and skidding halfway across the tent, she assumes. "I got hit in the fight earlier and when I fucked up the bandage I just went to go lay down and die in a pond instead."

"What the *fuck* ," Glimmer says hoarsely, which is about what she'd expected, "Catra, why didn't you tell anyone? Why didn't you, I don't know, *tie a proper fucking bandage* ?"

"Cannon fodder," Catra gets out through gritted teeth.

"What?"

"Cannon fodder," Adora repeats. Her voice becomes duller, muted. It's a little like watching the sun vanish behind the clouds, Catra thinks. "That's all we were, in the Horde. At least, until we started showing some value. You don't really get taught first aid training because you don't need it. What good is teaching a walking corpse to patch itself up?"

"And it's a little hard to tie a proper fucking bandage when you're rapidly losing blood, Sparkles," Catra mutters.

“You two are abysmally fucked up,” Glimmer says. She gave up on the anxious pacing at some point — now she’s kneeling beside Catra on the floor, hands braced on her thighs. “I cannot fucking *believe* they —”

“No point getting angry about it, war’s over,” Catra mumbles.

Her face hardens. “There is every point getting angry over it, and the only reason I am not blowing the roof off this tent right now is because you’re recovering from losing twice your body weight in blood.”

“That’s not medically possible —” Adora starts. Glimmer vanishes in a puff of glitter before she can finish, which makes Catra start coughing all over again.

When she reappears, Adora has finished up and is in the process of lifting Catra back into the bed. She doesn’t jolt, nor does she react much when Catra yelps and nearly flails out of her arms, which she appreciates.

“You two are going back to Bright Moon now,” Glimmer says tightly.

Adora raises her eyebrows. “Just the two of us?”

“Just the two of you,” she repeats. “Be glad I’m getting you out of patrol duty on the way back.”

“I don’t mind patrol duty,” Catra starts to say. Glimmer raises a hand — politely, actually, which is a change — for her to stop before she can find anything else to follow it up with.

“I also didn’t book you in for the infirmary because I know you’d be insufferable the whole time.”

“Oh, joy. So I can lie in peace in our nice dark bedroom until you come back in, like, a week.”

“Exactly,” Glimmer says.

Adora grins at her, that bright brilliant smile she fell for a million times over before she was old enough to know what love was. “Oh, so we can talk about it then, right?”

Catra sticks her tongue out at her. It seems appropriate.

Glimmer glances between them, eyebrows rising further and further towards her hairline. “Do I even want to know?”

“No,” Catra says, at the same time as Adora shrugs, “Well, I mean, it’s not too bad.”

“It is absolutely that bad and we need to discuss it,” Catra says to her, and then to Glimmer, “don’t fucking ask, trust me.”

Adora snorts. Glimmer groans.

End Notes

if you enjoyed this pls leave a comment/kudos and come say hi on tumblr @nonbinarychaoticstupid! and please feel free to let me know if i left anything out of the content warnings/descriptions because i wrote this all in a rush and wrapped it up fast. the idea was always to give it a bit of an open ending the same way she-ra leaves room for the characters to evolve gently past the show at their own rate but like. feel free to tell me if i fucked it up a little lol

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!